



Shivaji's grandson Sahu, and Bajirabhu Deshpande, who sacrificed his life to save Shivaji in 1660 during the famous battle of Pawankhind. This small group of soldiers was not just blue-blooded Kshatriyas, the warrior clan, but people from all sections of society, including high-caste Brahmins—like Moro Pant Pingle and Shankaraji Narayan—and low-caste barbers as well as Muslims. While Shivaji is the most famous name in Maratha history, these unknown warriors are hardly known outside Maharashtra.

Four centuries down the line, descendants of these soldiers live a middle- to higher middle-class existence in and around Pune and Kolhapur in wadas (havelis) and modern bungalows. Some are farmers; others are professionals and businessmen. The descendant of Jiva Mahale—Shivaji's bodyguard who saved him by killing Bijapur's general Afzal Khan—lives in poverty. But the one thing that binds them together is pride in the deeds of chivalry and loyalty of their ancestors and an urge to live up to their great reputation.

Ranojirao Ghorpade, grandson of Shivaji's general Santaji Ghorpade, an ace marksman and a one-time hunter, is bitter. "When India fails to give an effective reply to Pakistan's covert aggression, I feel like picking up a gun and taking on the Pakistanis in the tradition of my ancestors. I regret I didn't join the army." His grandfather had continued to fight Aurangzeb's armies after the death of Sambaji, who was killed by the emperor for not



**MARATHA  
WARRIOR JIVA  
MAHALE'S KIN  
BALKRISHNA  
SAPKAL (ABOVE)  
LIVES IN POVERTY  
WITH HIS WIFE  
AFTER HE WAS  
PARALYSED. HIS  
LANDS WERE  
GRABBED BY  
POLITICIANS.**



**JAYAWANTRAO  
MOHITE (LEFT)  
DESCENDS  
FROM SHIVAJI'S  
COMMANDER  
HAMBIRRAO  
MOHITE. HE IS  
ONE OF THE  
FEW MEN IN  
HIS FAMILY WHO  
DID NOT JOIN  
THE ARMY**